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BENGAL ABROAD CM Mamata Banerjee in London, March 24

external affairs had denied her permission to travel abroad on multiple occasions. In 2021, her trip to Rome was cancelled after her approval was withheld. However, her warm welcome in London by the high commissioner marked a stark shift in stance. A post on Mamata's official X handle acknowledged it in genteel diplomatese, saying, "it was a privilege to be hosted by Shri Vikram K. Doraiswami at India House, London, for a high tea reception. The gathering brought together a diverse spectrum of voices united in their commitment to strengthening Bengal-Britain ties. As we navigate a changing world, meaningful partnerships driven by trust are more vital than ever." Images from the event portrayed the bonhomie. She presented Doraiswami with one of her books and paintings, while the envoy also attended her business meetings the following day. "The stance our foreign office has taken regarding her visit this time is a complete reversal of its previous approach," a TMC source notes. "There could be a couple of reasons for this. First, Bengal is now among the Indian states that can be promoted as an investment destination abroad. Second, Didi's political influence at home has grown considerably in recent years."

Not everything went smoothly though. At Kellogg College, left-wing student activists from the UK wing of the CPI(M)-affiliated Students' Federation of India protested her presence, raising concerns about political violence, women's safety and campus elections in Bengal. Mamata dismissed them, urging them to strengthen their party in the state instead. Protesters also raised concerns about attacks on Hindus, which she sidestepped. BJP's Amit Malviya criticised Mamata, accusing her of failing to protect Hindus and women. He also condemned her disagreement with India's projected economic rise. Mamata responded with sarcasm and tact, asserting that the protesters were disrespecting their institution rather than confronting her. "Mamatadi didn't lose her cool at all. She even wanted the protesters to continue because she believes in their democratic right to protest, but it was the general public who drove them out," Ghosh, who was present at the event, remarks.

For all the political theatre, the real test of the visit lies in outcomes. Will foreign investors show interest in Bengal? Will a direct Kolkata-London flight resume? As of now, the trip's biggest accomplishment is its optics—TMC's recurring narrative of portraying the BJP as a party of outsiders, opposing a woman leader who is "making Bengal proud", will only be reinforced. Whether that translates into electoral benefits remains to be seen. ■